



1 Receptive skills: reading for gist and detail

Receptive skills · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Reading receptively means moving between two speeds: skimming quickly for gist (topic, purpose, audience, tone) and scanning closely for detail (names, numbers, dates, specific opinions). IB English B reading tasks combine question types such as multiple choice, true/false with justification, matching headings, and short-answer, so identify what each question is asking before searching the text. Use text-type clues (headline, layout, source, images) to predict content and register before reading line by line.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Text-type clue: a bulleted flyer headed 'Volunteers Needed This Saturday' signals gist (a call to action for an event) before any detail is read. Scanning for detail then locates the exact time ('9 a.m. at Riverside Park') and contact email, without re-reading the whole flyer.

Quick check · multiple choice

A student needs to find the exact closing date for a competition mentioned in a long online article. Which strategy is most efficient?

- A Reading the article aloud from start to finish
- B Skimming the title and first paragraph only
- C Scanning the text for numbers and date-related words
- D Translating the whole article into their first language

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Read the short notice below, then answer the four questions in complete sentences. [20]

NOTICE: The Greenfield Community Centre is launching a free Saturday coding club for students aged 12-16. Registration opens 1 October and closes 20 October. Places are limited to 24 students, and each participant should bring a laptop if possible; centre laptops will be available for those who do not have one.

1. What is the main purpose of this notice? (gist)
2. By what date must a student register? (detail)
3. Which age group is the club aimed at? (detail)
4. What does the notice suggest a student do if they do not own a laptop? (detail/inference)

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

A strong answer:

- Q1 (gist): identifies the overall purpose in one clear sentence, e.g. 'to inform students about a new free coding club and how to join', without copying the whole notice
- Q2 (detail): states the exact date '20 October' taken directly from the text
- Q3 (detail): states '12-16 year olds' precisely, not a vague paraphrase
- Q4 (inference): explains that the student can use a centre laptop, showing understanding of the conditional information
- All answers written in complete sentences, in the student's own words where paraphrase is required, with no unnecessary copying of full sentences

Quick check answer

C. Scanning targets specific details like dates efficiently, without needing full comprehension of every sentence.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

Original FagusED teaching material. Not an official IB publication; the sample scenarios and language are invented and generic.